

Full Screen

A lively introduction to Hindi cinema's glitzy A-list



BOLLYWOOD TODAY
by KAVEREER BAMZAI
Roli Books
Price: Rs 795
Pages: 173

■ By Nasreen Munni Kabir

With evocative and lush film stills and thumbnail sketches of the big names, from Amitabh Bachchan to Preity Zinta, Kaveree Bamzai's book is an up-to-date and lively introduction to Hindi cinema's A-list. *Bollywood Today* also provides a potted history of the movie-making decades and profiles filmmakers from Yash Chopra to Nagesh Kukunoor, whose cinematic ambitions are vastly different.

Bamzai has an interesting take on many stars. Of particular interest is her succinct piece on Sanjay Dutt, whom she describes as having "had so many incarnations that to call him the king of comebacks would be the greatest cliché as well as the undeniable truth", adding, "but no one can argue that Sanjay Dutt's life is far more enthralling than any character he has played".

The author, who has been writing on cinema for years, presents a clued-in portrait of the world of Hindi films. The reader is taken on a fascinating, but all too brief, journey through the corridors of the Yash Raj Films studios. Bamzai captures well the atmosphere of this successful production house and its inhabitants, and her impressions whet the reader's appetite for the how and why of filmmaking.

Bollywood Today is an enjoyable and informative read, even if it treads familiar territory. Writing about Hindi cinema is a strangely complex task. Books on the subject are increasingly meant for the widest possible audience, and the writer must speak to "those who know everything and those who know nothing". Here's hoping the introductions will soon be over and we will finally get a glimpse into the minds of the people behind the movies. Bamzai already seems to be on the track to writing such a book. ■

TOP 10

BESTSELLERS

A monthly national list of bestselling books compiled for INDIA TODAY by ORG-MARG based on data from 15 retail outlets in six cities.

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	A Thousand Splendid Suns	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury
2. (2)	Playing for Pizza	John Grisham	Random House
3. (3)	The Kite Runner	Khaled Hosseini	Bloomsbury
4. (-)	The Memory Keeper's Daughter	Kim Edwards	Penguin
5. (-)	The Interpretation Of Murder	Jed Rubenfeld	Headline Book Publishing

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
1. (1)	The Secret	Rhonda Byrne	Atria
2. (-)	The Last Mughal	William Dalrymple	Penguin
3. (-)	In Spite of the Gods: The Strange Rise of Modern India	Edward Luce	Random House
4. (9)	The Elephant, the Tiger and the Cellphone: Reflections on India in the 21st Century	Shashi Tharoor	Penguin

OTHER INDIAN BOOKS IN THE TOP 20

F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
6. (4)	Shantaram	Gregory David Roberts	Penguin
10. (9)	The Inheritance of Loss	Kiran Desai	Penguin

N O N - F I C T I O N

NO.	TITLE	AUTHOR	PUBLISHER
7. (14)	India After Gandhi: The History of the World's Largest Democracy	Ramachandra Guha	Picador
10. (-)	India's Unending Journey	Mark Tully	Rider Books
11. (3)	Buddha: A Story of Enlightenment	Deepak Chopra	HarperCollins
13. (-)	The Saint, the Surfer and the CEO	Robin S. Sharma	Hay House

Last month's rating in brackets

Participating bookshops: Delhi: Om Book Shop, Faqir Chand, Teksons, Full Circle; Mumbai: Crossword, Shah Book Stall, Danai Book Shop; Bangalore: Fountainhead, Gangarams; Hyderabad: Walden Book Link, The Book Point; Kolkata: Oxford Books, Modern Book Depot, Family Book Shop; Chennai: Fountainhead